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THE story of the exposure of the *Donation of Constantine* is a familiar one. In the middle of the fifteenth century, it will be recalled, two different men, writing independently of each other in England and in Italy, demonstrated conclusively that the document was a forgery. Others had long suspected it and, on one occasion at least, carefully examined and rejected it.¹ But it was left to Reginald Pecock and Lorenzo Valla to complete the criticism. When they were finished it was difficult, if not impossible, to continue to believe in either the document or the event. In this way, European historiography took a major step forward and the Renaissance relieved itself of one of the many legends that cluttered its understanding of the past.

Unfortunately, the tale, in this version, is too simple. For one thing, conviction in the *Donation* survived the assault.² For another, the co-

¹ Nicholas of Cusa in his *De Concordantia Catholica* (1432–1435), Book III, chap. ii; cf. *Opera* (Basle, 1565), reprinted in Christopher Coleman, *Constantine the Great and Christianity*, Columbia University Studies in History, Economics and Public Law, LX, no. 1 (1914), Appendix II, pp. 228–237. For the use and criticism of the *Donation* in the Middle Ages, J. J. von Döllinger, *Fables Respecting the Popes*, trans. Alfred Plummer (London, 1871), pp. 89–103; F. Zinkeisen, 'The *Donation of Constantine* as applied by the Roman Church', *English Historical Review*, IX (1894), 625–632; Gerhard Laehr, *Die Konstantinische Schenkung in der abendländischen Literatur des Mittelalters* (Berlin, 1926; reprinted Vaduz, 1965); V. H. H. Green, 'The *Donation of Constantine*', *Church Quarterly Review*, CXXXV (1943), 39–63; Walter Ullmann, *Medieval Papalism* (London, 1949); *The Growth of Papal Government in the Middle Ages*, 2d ed. (reprinted London, 1965); Domenico Maffei, *La Donazione di Costantino nei Giuristi Medievali* (Milano, 1964); Giovanni Antonazzi, 'Lorenzo Valla e la Donazione di Costantino nel secolo XV', *Rivista di Storia della Chiesa in Italia*, IV (1950), 186–223.

² The *Donation* was defended, for example, by Augustinus Steuchus, *Contra Laurentium Vallum in Falsa Donatione Constantini* (Lyon, 1547) and answered by Calvin in the *Institutes*, IV, xi, 12. For evidence of continuing debate into the seventeenth century, see Richard Crakanthorpe, *The Defense of Constantine* (London, 1621). There are useful citations in Maffei, pp. 321 ff.; L. D. Ettlinger, *The Sistine Chapel before Michaelangelo* (Oxford, 1965), p. 111 n.

incidence of the criticism of Pecock and Valla was merely fortuitous.³ In neither purpose nor method, background nor influence, did the effort of the two men have very much in common. Finally, their achievement was not at all unambiguously progressive; their anticipation of a modern conclusion (for the *Donation* is indeed a forgery) conceals the fact that their historiographical techniques were rooted solidly in their own time and remain quite remote from the present. It is the purpose of this paper to try to dispel some of these confusions. In so doing, I shall not advance anything very startling; I shall simply try to show that the two contemporary critics of the *Donation* inhabited essentially different intellectual worlds, and that they each employed the characteristic devices of their training for the solution of a practical problem: scholastic logic in Pecock's case, humanist grammar and rhetoric in the case of Valla. That the different elements of the trivium were often opposed during the Renaissance is well known; that they were antithetical in their relationship to historiography, perhaps less so. In any case, the comparison between Pecock and Valla affords a rare opportunity to compare in detail the different approaches of a scholastic logician and a renaissance philologist to a common historical problem and thus to illuminate each. Incidentally, it allows us also to place the episode in relation to the evolution of modern historiography. In the end, as we shall see, it is Pecock with his syllogistic logic who proves the more alien to modernity, while Valla, with his new philological method, though promising much for the future, only begins to point the way.⁴

³ There is, for example, no reason to suppose that Pecock had read Valla as H. Maynard Smith alleges in his *Pre-Reformation England* (London, 1938), p. 422.

⁴ For the alleged modernity of Pecock, see most recently Arthur B. Ferguson, 'Reginald Pecock and the Renaissance Sense of History', *Studies in the Renaissance*, xiii (1966), 147–165. Ferguson speaks of the essentially 'medieval' character of Pecock's thought but nevertheless insists upon his anticipation of renaissance humanism. He does not say much about the *Donation*, however. For the older view in its extreme form, that Pecock was 'too modern even for some people who live in the twentieth century', see E. M. Blackie, 'Reginald Pecock', *English Historical Review*, xxvi (1911), 448–468, and J. L. Morison, ed., *The Book of Faith* (Glasgow, 1909), pp. 76–79; for echoes in the more recent literature see E. F. Jacob, 'Reginald Pecock', *Proceedings of the British Academy*, xxxvii (1951), 144; V. H. H. Green, 'Bishop Pecock and the English Bible', *Church Quarterly Review*, cxxix (1940), 281 n.

I

Of Pecock's career not much need be said. Indeed most of it, including the dates and circumstances of both birth and death, remain obscure.⁵ We do know that he attended Oxford University from about 1409 to 1424 and that he received a Doctor of Divinity degree there, some twenty years later. Unfortunately, the university had passed its great days; Grosseteste and Roger Bacon, Scotus and Ockham, even Wyclif, were long gone, although their works lived on in different ways after them. Students were scarce and outstanding teachers even more so. But the curriculum remained intact: the familiar scholastic education of the medieval university designed to train clerics in theology and law, and built almost exclusively upon the instruments of logic and dialectic. Rhetoric and grammar, the other kindred disciplines of the trivium, were either ignored or subordinated. The chief aim, as the statutes of 1431 made plain, was to train the student 'to analyze and subdivide, to know the pros and cons of every argument, to be alert in disputation, in posing questions, and in suggesting replies'.⁶ There was no need here for literature in general, or for the classical authors more specifically.⁷ And there was no place whatever for the study of history, ancient or modern. It is clear that Pecock thoroughly mastered the Oxford curriculum: his works display the same pre-occupation with logic and dialectic, the same ignorance of Latin and Greek literature.

Pecock's career was less typical than his course of study. Upon leaving the university, he became rector of a Gloucester church, then, in succession, Master of Whittington College, London (1431), Bishop of St. Asaph (1444), and finally Bishop of Chichester (1450) and member of the Privy Council (1454). Unfortunately his preferment was advanced by the Lancastrian party and, with the accession of the Yorkists, his downfall was even more precipitous than his rise. But his failure was more than simply the result of politics; for some years a large clerical

⁵ For the details of Pecock's life, see John Lewis, *The Life of Reginald Pecock* (London, 1744); Churchill Babington, ed., *The Repressor of Over Much Blaming of the Clergy* (Rolls Series, no. 19, 1860), I, intro.; V. H. H. Green, *Bishop Reginald Pecock* (Cambridge, 1945); Jacob, *op. cit.*; A. B. Emden, *A Biographical Register of the University of Oxford* (Oxford, 1959), III, 'Pecock'.

⁶ Charles Mallet, *A History of the University of Oxford* (London, 1924), I, 186.

⁷ Always excepting Aristotle, whose works were largely known in translation. Even so, it was the logical, scientific, and metaphysical writings that were studied to the neglect of the *Rhetoric* and *Poetics*.

party had been leveling allegations of heresy at him, and the combined pressures of temporal and religious opposition resulted ultimately (1457–1458) in a public recantation of heresy, the burning of his books, resignation from office, and incarceration in an abbey for his remaining days.

It was an ironic end. Pecock saw himself throughout his life as the self-appointed champion of orthodoxy against the challenge of Wyclif and Lollardy. He was familiar with the heresy from his days at the university, where it lingered despite vigorous measures to eradicate it, and more especially from his life in London. In twenty years, he wrote perhaps fifty apologetic works (although only five survive) meant to vindicate the church exactly as he found it with all its imperfections. It is in this context, as we shall see, that he wrote the work known as the *Repressor of Overmuch Blaming the Clergy*, in the course of which he exposed the *Donation*. But his accusers found that ‘the damnable doctrine and pestiferous sect of Reginald Pecock exceedeth in malice and horribility all the other heresies and sects of heretics heretofore known . . .’. The defense of orthodoxy had somehow led the bishop into heresy.⁸

The paradox of Pecock’s career was rooted in his attitude to what he calls the ‘doom of reason’. The Lollards had argued that man’s reason was ‘a thing which in his dooms and judgments oft faileth’. For every truth, they insisted upon a Scriptural citation; on any point, they asked but one thing: Where groundest thou it in Holy Scripture?⁹ Pecock’s reply was to defend and to exalt reason as a separate and legitimate avenue to knowledge about sacred things. But to do so he appeared to elevate reason above Scripture, as well as above the Church fathers and tradition; and these were the charges laid against him and which he afterwards recanted.¹⁰

In fact, Pecock’s teaching was more complicated. But it is undoubtedly worth some attention here because it provides the only appropriate

⁸ *Repressor*, I, 1v, n. The paradox was continued in the next century when the English Protestants adopted Pecock as a forerunner and placed him thereby back among the Lollards. See, for example, John Foxe, *The Acts and Monuments*, 4th ed., ed. Joseph Pratt (London, 1870), III, 731–734. *The Index Expurgatorius* of Madrid even described him as a Lutheran professor of Oxford (Smith, p. 287).

⁹ *Repressor*, I, 73, 6.

¹⁰ Thomas Gascoigne, *Loci e Libro Veritatum*, ed. James E. Thorold Rogers (Oxford, 1881), p. xlii. See also *An English Chronicle*, ed. J. S. Davies (Camden Society, 1856), p. 77; *Brief Latin Chronicle* in *Three Fifteenth Century Chronicles*, ed. J. Gairdner (Camden Society, 1880), p. 167.

context in which to understand his attack upon the *Donation*. To determine his position it is helpful to draw upon all the surviving works, along with the *Repressor*. Indeed, Pecock himself urges this upon us with an elaborate system of cross-references to his own writings. He clearly meant them to be taken as a whole, a kind of *Summa Theologiae* in which everything found its logical place.¹¹ He even says that he worked upon several treatises at one time; and his continuous rewriting makes them impossible to date exactly. His teaching is therefore very much the same whether in the *Repressor* or in the *Book of Faith*, which seems to have been written just before his downfall, or in the *Reule of Chrysten Religion*, which was apparently the first of his works.

What did Pecock understand to be the relation between reason and faith? It was a problem familiar enough in scholastic literature. Pecock resolved it by radically separating the two; reason and faith (philosophy and divinity), are, he writes, 'two diverse faculties each of them having his proper to him bounds and marks . . . truths and conclusions'.¹² Neither may be used to prove the truths of the other. At the same time, Pecock limits the conclusions of faith while he extols the range and competence of the rational faculty. Each is legitimate and valuable, but 'doom of reason' is more extensive, more reliable, and in a sense more valuable, than knowledge of Scripture. Pecock, it seems, is hard to fit into any convenient scholastic category; his conclusions are equally removed from St. Thomas and from Scotus (both of whose works he knew and cites) and from most other medieval thinkers.¹³ It is his confidence in reason that sets him apart and that has given him (for some at least) a thoroughly modern air.

By reason Pecock meant the logic of the syllogism. He never tires of extolling its value as a means to truth. Give him two premises that are reliable and he will deduce a third that is also true, 'though all the angels in heaven would say and hold that conclusion were not true'.¹⁴ The reasoning of a syllogism is as true and compulsive to a Moslem or Jew as to a Christian. Indeed, when full and formal, logic 'faileth never, neither

¹¹ William C. Greet, ed., *The Reule of Crysten Religioun*, Early English Text Society, orig. ser., 171 (1927), p. xiii; Elsie V. Hitchcock, ed., *The Donet*, Early English Text Society, orig. ser., 156 (1921), p. xvii.

¹² *Repressor*, I, 49–50.

¹³ Green, *op. cit.*, pp. 84–87; Jacob, pp. 149–150; Greet, pp. xiv–xv.

¹⁴ *Repressor*, I, 8; *Book*, pp. 125–126. The arguments of syllogisms give us 'well nigh all things which a man know other wise than a beast knows' E. V. Hitchcock, ed., *The Follower to the Donet*, Early English Text Society, orig. ser., 164 (1924), p. 9.

in any time [doth] err'. Men are only deceived in reasoning when they are too impatient to reduce an argument to syllogisms or when the premises are not sufficiently grounded. The twenty types of syllogism, Pecock is confident, cover all the possibilities of argument although he has not the time to illustrate them. Still, he hopes that even the common people may be taught logic—so universal is its value—and expects some day to write a vernacular handbook for the purpose.¹⁵ It is not the least of Pecock's claims to originality that he wrote most of his works in English. It was obviously not easy nor was there any precedent for turning a systematic scholastic philosophy (with its complex technical vocabulary) into a readable fifteenth-century English.

But the syllogism depends for its value on its premises and these may be either certain or probable. A premise is certain when it is self-evident. Here perhaps, Pecock is less helpful than he might be. Certainty is defined simply as when 'experience of sensitive wit or at full plain in reason' is so 'openly true' that no man can err.¹⁶ A premise is only probable, on the other hand, when the arguments on one side cannot be overborne by arguments on the other, when it is 'so likely true that it is rather to be hold for true than for untrue'. Dialectic, the *sic et non*, is thus the instrument which is used here, and at each stage of argument, to establish a probable truth.¹⁷ Together, dialectic and the syllogism provide a method sufficient to combat any heresy. Pecock is so optimistic of the power of reason that he is even led to advocate toleration. Let all opinion, he urges, be so secure that anyone 'come and go and speak and argue and answer without bodily harm and without any loss of his riches or fame'.¹⁸ We are reminded again of the irony of Pecock's career.

But not all truth is known by reason; there are also truths of faith. These are known 'by the assertion or the witnessing of a person, which is not likely therein to make leasing and to beguile'.¹⁹ Pecock is concerned, of course, primarily with vindicating Scripture. Even so, he finds it useful to justify the knowledge of faith by an appeal to reason. Such knowledge is not derived from reason but it is determined to be knowledge by reason. After all, how does one know whether Scripture is reliable in the first place? How can one determine the extent of Scrip-

¹⁵ *Reule*, pp. 428–429; *Repressor*, I, 76.

¹⁶ *Repressor*, I, 76.

¹⁷ *Reule*, 425–426; *Repressor*, I, 42, 97.

¹⁸ *Repressor*, I, 99; *Book*, p. 139.

¹⁹ *Repressor*, I, 131.

tural truth? The meaning of a Scriptural passage? For Pecock, unlike the Lollards, these things are not immediately apparent, nor are they the result of the goodness of the believer. They are problems resolvable only by the intellect, by the doom of reason. Thus, 'if any seeming discord be betwixt the words written in the outward book of Holy Scripture and the doom of reason . . . the words so written withoutforth ought be expounded and interpreted and brought for to accord with the doom of reason in that matter'. But never the reverse.²⁰ It was this conviction that eventually led the bishop into charges of heresy.

Pecock develops his idea of Scriptural exegesis at some length. It is interesting to us both because it helps to define Pecock's idea of history and because it allows a useful contrast with Valla. Scripture, he writes, contains three kinds of matter. In the first place there is supernatural information, beyond the reach of reason, like knowledge of the Trinity. All that reason can do here is to show that Scripture is not likely to have lied.²¹ In the second place there is matter that is agreeable to reason. Finally, there is history, that is to say, 'fetes, works, and deeds of creatures—as is, that such a king did such a victory and that such a person came of such a father and had such a progeny'. Knowledge here depends on the 'credence giving to the revelator and to the teller thereof which must be such as we ought always know and trust for his truth'. In the case of Scripture this means applying two tests: first, comparing it with other Scriptural testimony to see that there is no contradiction; second, seeing that it does not conflict with reason. In the case of human testimony, 'in storying or chronicling, or by speech of himself or of his messenger without writing', knowledge is also an act of faith dependent on reason.²² But here Pecock is less explicit; he is after all not really concerned with secular history. Still, one can infer his method readily enough; he would no doubt compare authorities, examine their 'credibility' by the integrity of their characters, and then measure the result

²⁰ 'The doom of reason ought not for to be expounded, glossed, interpreted, and brought for to accord with the said outward writing in Holy Scripture.' It is the Bible not reason which is malleable. *Repressor*, I, 25–26; *Follower*, p. 10; *Book*, p. 126; *Reule*, p. 464. There are, however, truths known to faith and not to reason (*Reule*, pp. 202 ff.). Cf. Everett H. Everson, 'Reginald Pecock, Christian Rationalist', *Speculum*, xxxi (1956), 235–242.

²¹ *Reule*, p. 461. He advises the expositor to keep to the literal interpretation, however, and to use interpretations especially of those 'wise holy lettered clerks which lived in the time of the apostles and were hearers and scholars of the apostles . . .'.

²² *Ibid.*, p. 133.

against the doom of reason. It is in fact the very method that he employs with *The Donation of Constantine*.

A more concrete example of his approach to history is his explanation of *Genesis*. The problem here occurs in a dialogue between father and son known as the *Book of Faith*.²³ The son is troubled over the fact that no Scripture existed before Moses. That means to him that before Moses oral tradition had been sufficient. Why, he wants to know, is it no longer? Why did Moses need to receive it by inspiration and prophecy?

The father replies by setting up the problem as a dialectical question. If one could prove that it was more likely that no writing on the faith existed before Moses than the opposite, then we might indeed wonder why we would need a written Scripture. But the probability of the contrary is in fact much stronger. For when we read the Master of the Stories (i.e., the twelfth-century writer Peter Comestor) we discover that learning in the seven sciences was invented shortly after Noah's time. Likely enough then, there was writing of the faith soon after the Flood, since writing existed and there were men of faith. But there is evidence that, even before the Flood, Enoch had found letters (the authority is again Peter Comestor). Since the Bible says Enoch was a holy man who lived in the days of Adam, it is likely again that he wrote of holy matters even then. Moreover it is probable that Noah, himself a holy man, would have protected these writings on his ship. His preaching against sin would clearly have profited from such 'great cunning of full ghostly things'. Another likelihood is that Enoch would have given his writing to his son Methuselah, from whom it could again have come to Noah. Noah would surely have passed it on to his sons and they to Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and so on, each no doubt adding an account of his own. 'And so at the last, Moses gathered all this together, and made a book thereof which is called Genesis.'²⁴

This chain of probabilities seems to Pecock altogether more likely than the story of divine inspiration, depending as it does upon a miracle. Indeed, belief in miracles is for him a last resort only, since we ought not to 'feign, forge, allege, put, trow, or hold any miracle to be done, save when need compelleth us thereto'. The haste to explain by means of a

²³ Pt. II, chap. III, pp. 261 ff.

²⁴ Compare *Reule*, pp. 431 ff. For Pecock's source, see S. R. Daly, 'Peter Comestor: Master of Histories', *Speculum*, XXXII (1957), 62-73.

miracle makes nonsense of any resort to evidence.²⁵ In this case at least, there is a plausible alternative. The evidence we have suggests that a written Scripture did exist before Moses and grew gradually over the generations until its final redaction by him.

It is startling to see Pecock anticipating the conclusions of the modern higher criticism in so curious a fashion. It is very like what he does with the *Donation*. His chain of deductions from a twelfth-century source leads him to a viewpoint about the composition of Genesis somewhat similar to that derived by modern textual criticism but utterly without its foundation. Needless to say, the co-incidence in conclusions tells us nothing about Pecock's modernity or his understanding of historical criticism. The notion that he possessed 'a historical sense, unequalled in England for more than a century, and a capacity for the scientific viewpoint' begins to seem unlikely.²⁶ The bishop simply did not understand the modern pre-occupation with original sources or their criticism.

But Pecock has a second and more general argument against the oral tradition. Take heed, the father cautions the son, how 'a tale of a tiding, by the time that it hath run through four or five men's mouths, taketh patches and clouts and is changed in divers parts, and turned into leasings, and all for default of, therof the writing'.²⁷ It is impossible to imagine transmitting the long tale of the Scriptures truly, through centuries of oral repetition. Especially is this unimaginable when we realize that language itself changes through time and place until it becomes impossible to understand a man of another country and century. Pecock is obviously sensitive to the limits of oral testimony; in another place he suggests its failings for contemporary affairs.²⁸ But he is apparently quite unaware that the same alterations and inaccuracies are possible in the transmission of a written text. There was apparently nothing in the logician's training to suggest the problem. This, despite the fact that he understands that the Bible is in one sense just like any other document. 'Holy Writ', he notices, 'may be taken for the outward letters written and shaped under divers figures in parchment or in vellum.' Taken in

²⁵ 'For else there might none opinion be overcome by strength of argument, how false ever the opinion were, so that he included no repugnance, such as God might not do by miracle' (Book, p. 270). For Pecock's general aversion to miracles see also *Book*, p. 294; *Repressor*, II, 353–354.

²⁶ Morison, introd. to *Book of Faith*, p. 76.

²⁷ *Ibid.*, pp. 250–251; compare *Reule*, p. 433.

²⁸ *Book of Faith*, p. 252 (re the Hundred Years' War).

this sense, he continues, it 'is not holier neither better than any other writing in which hath like good ink, and is like craftily figured'.²⁹ But this is not the sense that interests him; he is concerned with the inner meaning where reason, not textual criticism rules, and so he passes on to other things. For the humanist, by contrast, the textual problem was at once obvious and to the point. Valla saw immediately that the corruption of the New Testament had occurred through the passage of time and that the errors of scribes and translators had obscured its meaning; he also, as we shall see, tried to remedy it.

The example of the *Donation* is even more revealing, however, of both the extent and the limits of Pecock's historiographical technique. The Lollards had attacked the Church for many abuses, among them its great wealth and endowments. They had urged many arguments against them and Pecock was at pains to refute them all. The Lollards had charged among other things, that as 'the Church waxed in dignities it decreased in virtues', and they found in the *Donation of Constantine* one ultimate cause. That document purported to describe the gift by the Emperor Constantine to the Pope of great temporal possessions. The Lollards repeated the story that at the time of the endowment the voice of an angel was heard to cry, 'In this day venom is hilded into the church of God!'³⁰ In other words the endowment of the clergy with great territory was 'unvirtuous and evil'. To refute the charge, Pecock felt that he must refute the story of the angel's voice, and this he does, by first refuting the *Donation*. The larger question depends for him on the resolution of the subordinate *quaestio*; the refutation of the *Donation* is to take the form of a scholastic disputation.

It was a strange thing for Pecock to do. The *Donation* had been used for centuries, had indeed been invented in the first place in order to justify the papal claims to her endowments. Its criticism, both earlier and later, depended for its motives largely upon the attack on those papal privileges. Yet Pecock meant to refute the *Donation* for the same purpose for which it had been invented, i.e., to justify the papal claims. Only a logician with a supreme confidence in reason could have imagined such an undertaking.

Pecock begins with the story of the angel's voice. He argues first that the tale originated with Geraldus Cambrensis, the twelfth-century

²⁹ *Repressor*, I, 81.

³⁰ *Ibid.*, II, 322–323, 350 ff. Wyclif, *Dialogus*, IV, chap. 18. For other contemporary references see Babington, *Repressor*, II, 323, n.

Welsh chronicler. However, Gerald told it, he finds, not of a good angel but rather of the devil. Obviously, one may give little credence to the voice of a 'fiend'. Not content, he next assails Gerald's reliability. It is hard to believe the tale when 'no other story or chronicle can be found written down, though no such storying or writing is had thereupon'.³¹ Having cast suspicion on the angel's voice, Pecock next assails its foundation. He now challenges the story of Constantine's endowment, the alleged provocation of the angel.

The story Pecock inherited and which was generally believed in his day may be briefly told. Constantine, the Emperor of the West, had begun to persecute the Christians once again and forced Sylvester, Bishop of Rome, to take refuge. The Emperor was afflicted with leprosy, however, and sought a cure. He rejected the solution of pagan priests (a bath in the blood of infants) and was rewarded by a dream in which two figures appeared promising relief if he would but seek out Sylvester and obey him. This Constantine did. Sylvester showed him likenesses of Peter and Paul, whom Constantine identified as the visionary figures. The Pope then directed Constantine to submit to fasting and to baptism, upon which event Constantine was at once miraculously and, in a blaze of light, healed. In return, the Emperor at once directed Christianity to be adopted throughout the Empire and heavily endowed the Church. He built the Lateran Palace for the bishop as well as various places of worship, furnished them liberally, and supplied the Pope with his ceremonial garments, scepter, etc. Finally, and most munificently, he bestowed upon Sylvester the city of Rome and all the provinces of the West, transferring his own seat to Byzantium. Thus the miraculous cure of Constantine by Sylvester and the consequent donation of Constantine are the two main elements in the story Pecock received. Although they had had separate origins, they had long become interdependent.³² Pecock believed neither, and urged refutation of each as proof against the reliability of the other. His arguments are not easy to follow, especially in their scholastic form and fifteenth-century English; neverthe-

³¹ *Repressor*, II, 351–352, 357–358.

³² For the text of the *Donation*, see Coleman, *Constantine*, Appendix II, pp. 228–237, from Karl Zeumer, *Festgabe für Rudolf von Gneist* (Berlin, 1888), pp. 39 ff.; for the *Vita Sylvestri*, Coleman, Appendix I, pp. 217–227, from B. Mombritius, *Sanctuarium seu Vitae Sanctorum*, ed. H. Quentin and A. Brunet (Paris, 1910), II, 508–531. The *Life* preceded the *Donation*, apparently dating from the end of the fifth century; see W. Levison, 'Konstantinische Schenkung und Silvesterlegende', *Miscellanea Francesco Ehrle* (Rome, 1924), II, 181 ff., 239 ff.

less, they are worth restatement, if only because they have been so frequently misunderstood.

Pecock begins by examining the story of Constantine's baptism and cure. Immediately he insists upon the need for testimony. In general we ought not to believe such tales unless some 'storier or chronicler had written' of them. It is a virtue of Pecock's method in general that he is continuously insistent on the need for evidence. 'Our reason', he argues, 'may not know any truth and consent thereto without this, that our reason have evidences for to so consent.'³³ It is the historian's task to discover the 'fundamental undoubted evidences', the testimony for each incident. In this case, as it happens, there are witnesses on both sides. But if it can be shown conclusively that Constantine was *not* baptized in Rome, then the witnesses affirming it cannot be believed (and the story of the angel's voice must also fail). In short, we cannot believe both that Constantine was and that he was not baptized in Rome; we must choose the more probable story by examining the evidence on either side. As with the case of the Mosaic testimony, Pecock sets up the problem as a dialectical question. But his criteria for evidence and for probability are not in the end more persuasive here than they were for establishing his view of Genesis.

What evidence does Pecock have? Telling the miraculous tale he finds two sources, an anonymous life of Sylvester and the narrative in the *Liber Pontificalis*. From these, he is sure, the other histories and chronicles have derived their accounts. On the other side, he discovers an alternative story in the writings of Eusebius of Caesarea and in the *Tripartite History*. There, Constantine is said to have been baptized only at the end of his life at a city called Nicomedia by an ordinary bishop. Obviously, one may not believe both.

For Pecock the choice is clear; Eusebius is a reliable authority. No man would know better than he the circumstances of Constantine's baptism, for he was 'living and conversant with the same Constantine and was privy with Constantine in the councils of his heart and of his conscience'. Furthermore, Eusebius had been praised and celebrated by St. Jerome and the authors of the *Tripartite History*. Next to the Bible, his *Ecclesiastical History*, he declares, is the most famous and credible story known to Christians. And the *Life of Constantine* was the natural result of his having been 'so privey and so homely' with the Emperor.

³³ Reule, pp. 426. See also the manuscript fragment quoted by Lewes, *op. cit.*, p. 68.

That work then is the most reliable authority by the best informed of men and deserves full credence.³⁴ It is certainly worthier of belief than the sources of the alternative story. Of the *Life of Sylvester*, 'no man can tell who wrote it, neither whence it came, or whither it will'. Pecock reaffirms his suspicions of the miracles of saints lives in general: 'in legends be found many full untrue fables'. As for the account in the *Liber Pontificalis*, that was written long after the events by Pope Damasus and is not entirely reliable anyway.³⁵

Pecock adds two further arguments against the legendary story of Sylvester. First, he notices that both Ambrose and Jerome believed the alternative in Eusebius. But surely they would not have followed him against Damasus without sufficient evidence. Furthermore, the chronicles 'most credible next' to Eusebius, the *Tripartite* authors, also witness that Constantine was baptized just before his death at Nicomedia. These witnesses together surely outweigh the others and tell a story more credible than the contrary which must therefore be 'an apocrif'.

The ground is now clear for Pecock's assault on the *Donation* itself. The last prop for the tale of the angel's voice has to be removed. Constantine is shown to have made no endowment such as that usually attributed to him. Pecock's next argument, therefore, suggests that the first endowments of the Church had occurred much before Constantine. He cites two instances, the endowments made a hundred years earlier as recorded in Pope Urban's *Decrees* and those made earlier still by Pope Eleutherius to the British king, Lucius. Of both these endowments, 'old stories and chronicles (being famous and worthy and credible and not being apocriphs) make mention'. He then argues against the abundance of Constantine's endowments. The large donations attributed to him were only made much later by Pepin, Charles the Great, Ludovic, and Matilda. Here again, unnamed chronicles and stories are brought to bear witness.³⁶

³⁴ *Repressor*, II, 352–353. The *Tripartite History* was a condensed Latin version by the translator Epiphanius, guided by Cassiodorus, of the *Ecclesiastical Histories* of Socrates, Sozomen, and Theodoret. It seems to have first been criticized by the humanist Beatus Rhenanus in 1523. See M. L. W. Laistner, 'The Value and Influence of Cassiodorus' Ecclesiastical History', *Harvard Theological Review*, xli (1948), 51–67, reprinted in Chester G. Starr, ed., *The Intellectual Heritage of the Early Middle Ages* (Ithaca, 1957), pp. 22–39.

³⁵ *Repressor*, II, 353–354; *Book*, pp. 270, 294. Pecock finds a discrepancy between the Pseudo-Damasus and Jerome that undermines the authority of the *Liber*, *ibid.*, pp. 354, 359–360.

³⁶ *Ibid.*, II, 357–359. Most of this evidence is as suspect as the *Donation*.

But how to dispose of the detailed enumeration of gifts in the received story? Again Pecock marshals a number of arguments. First there is the argument from silence. If the *Donation* had existed surely there would have been 'some mention . . . in some fundamental and credible story or chronicle'. But in fact there is none except for the *Life of Sylvester* and the stories and chronicles that are based upon it. We have seen how little value they possess. Then, again, there are the alternative accounts of more reliable authorities. For example, the *Tripartite History* says that Constantine left his Empire to his three sons, including the western part, with the eldest son inheriting Rome. Again, Constantine's quick determination to move to the East to build Byzantium is contradicted by the story in the *Tripartite History*, which tells how Constantine meant to build his capital in another place altogether and even had some of it built when a warning in his sleep turned him aside from his program.

But most elaborate are his proofs drawn from the later history of Rome, all contradicting the story of the *Donation*. For example, about two hundred and fifty years afterwards, Pope Boniface IV wished to convert the Pantheon in Rome to a church. But he had to ask the eastern Emperor Phocas, 'leave for to so do'. Why should he have had to do this if Rome and the surrounding country were already his? Again, the chronicles show that from Constantine to Charlemagne there was an unbroken succession of Emperors who reigned over both East and West. It was only in Charlemagne's day that the Empire was divided and probably only then that the Popes gained lordship over Rome (and that at the behest of Charles and later Ludovic). Finally, Pecock asserts that for hundreds of years after Sylvester's death the elections of Popes had to be confirmed by the Emperors, 'as can be proved by sufficient credible chronicles and stories, and in special for to see in the chronicle of Martyn, where he speaketh of Pope Vitalian'.³⁷ Pecock does not deny the possibility of small endowments by Constantine; he is confident that his arguments refute the main point that Constantine had bestowed great lands and territorial sovereignty upon the Pope. If that was not done, there was no need for an angel to announce it. Pecock's argument is complete.

³⁷ *Ibid.*, II, 374. This is the thirteenth-century chronicler Martinus Polonus, who seems to have supplied most of this information to Pecock. His work is a brief world chronicle, from Creation to 1277. See the recent article by William Mathews in *Medieval Literature and Civilization: Studied in Memory of G. N. Garmonsway* (London, 1969), pp. 275-288.

How may we assess Pecock's performance? Certainly, his main conclusions are correct by the standards of modern scholarship. Neither angel's voice, nor miraculous conversion, nor *Donation of Constantine* is historically authentic. That is how Pecock has won his reputation for modernity. But this is surely to obscure the main issue: Pecock's method of arriving at his conclusions. Essentially what he did was to compare authorities and choose among them. As R. G. Collingwood has reminded us, however, the mere comparison of authorities to determine which is right and which is wrong is a kind of 'scissors and paste' historiography that the modern historian no longer finds adequate. (This, of course, is a special temptation to the logician who has no other means but to affirm or deny the consistency of a series of statements.) What we want to know of our sources now is what they meant, not simply whether they were right or wrong. We need not either reject or accept them wholly. If we know their purpose and intention we can then interpret their usefulness to the question at hand. But this Pecock has not done, not even for his favorite, Eusebius, and still less for the alternative accounts. What is the *Life of Sylvester* or the *Donation of Constantine*, if they are not what they seem? Why were they written and what was their intention?

But even in its own terms, Pecock's method is not completely successful. The number of his authorities is, for one thing, much too small.³⁸ Scholastic logic furnished little incentive and no technique for historical research. It *was* possible, for example, to find the story of the angel's voice long before Geraldus. It was also possible to find a wealth of information about Constantine's reign and the condition of the Church both before and after, all relevant to his argument. Ignorance of well-known Latin authorities and inability to read any Greek at all were, in the end, insurmountable handicaps to his position. Here the contemporary humanist Valla shows his great advantage. Yet examination of Pecock's own evidence is not more satisfactory. The chronicler 'Martyn', Martinus Polonus, is, for example, a thirteenth-century writer,

³⁸ There is a convenient and extensive list of authorities in Ernest C. Richardson, trans., *Eusebius: Constantine* (Oxford, 1890), pp. 336–344, 445 ff., and in Coleman, *Constantine*, pp. 25 ff. A brilliant account of the sources is included in Norman H. Baynes, 'Constantine the Great and the Christian Church', *Proceedings of the British Academy*, xv (1929), 341–442. Conspicuous by its absence among Pecock's authorities were some important literary works, especially the pamphlet by Lactantius *On the Deaths of the Persecutors* usually considered the most trustworthy literary account (see the edition by J. Moreau [Paris, 1954]), but especially the evidence of laws, coins, inscriptions, etc.

thought to be notoriously unreliable today; his value is exactly like Peter Comestor's for biblical events. Why is he 'sufficient credible' for Pecock? The gifts to the Church by Popes Urban and Eleutherius are as mythical as those of Constantine, and dependent upon authorities at least as untrustworthy. Nor was it Charlemagne who vested the Church with its Italian lands. The attack on the alternative authorities will not do either. What reason, besides the contradictions of allegedly more certain authorities, is there to suppose that the *Life of Sylvester*, the *Liber Pontificalis*,³⁹ or the *Donation* itself—not to mention the many corroborative chronicle accounts—are false? It is true that miraculous stories are to be received with caution. But does not Eusebius also tell us of a miracle by which Constantine was converted to the faith? Why then prefer the *Vita Constantini* to the *Vita Sylvestri*?⁴⁰ Indeed, if one simply reverses Pecock's skepticism, his arguments will work almost as well against Eusebius as they do against the *Donation*. It is true that the story of Pope Damasus is late, but then, so too was the *Tripartite History*, which Pecock relies on so heavily—especially in the only version known to him, the Latin abbreviation by Cassiodorus. How late were they? What was their point or purpose? In the end, Pecock's ideas of historical evidence and of historical probability were determined—like those of his Lollard opponents—more by his prejudices than by his methodological sophistication. His arguments may have afforded the fifteenth century an ingenious logical exercise; but they left the meaning and reliability of the documents, and therefore the history of his subject, pretty much where Pecock had found them. Thus the course of medieval historiography remained unaffected by his efforts.

In short, Pecock was not a modern critical historian. But his achievement was not for that reason negligible. The comparison of authorities is indeed a critical step, although a first step only. If Pecock invented no

³⁹ For the problems of the *Liber*, see the useful brief discussion in E. H. Davenport, *The False Decretals* (Oxford, 1916), pp. 64 ff.; L. Duchesne, *Le Liber Pontificalis: Texte, Introduction et Commentaire* (Paris, 1886), I, cix–cxx (text, 170–201). There is an English translation by Louise R. Loomis, *The Book of the Popes* (New York, 1916).

⁴⁰ Cf. Coleman, pp. 139, 154 ff.; Gibbon (Bury ed.), II, 305, n.; Baynes, pp. 396–398, 430–431. For the complex problems involved in the interpretation of this work, see especially H. Grégoire in *Revue de l'Université de Bruxelles*, xxxvi (1930), 231–272; *Byzantion*, xiii (1938), pp. 561–583; and *Bulletin de la Classe des lettres et des sciences morales et politiques* xxxix (1953), 462–478; also G. Downey in *Dumbarton Oaks Papers*, vi (1951), 57–66. For recent accounts favoring Eusebius, see Andrew Alföldi, *The Conversion of Constantine the Great*, trans. H. Mattingly (Oxford, 1948); A. H. M. Jones, *Constantine and the Conversion of Europe* (New York, 1962), pp. 73–90.

new method, it is fair to say that he at least invented a problem—difficult to avoid thereafter. And within the limits of his method he showed great ingenuity in solving it. How great we may see at once simply by comparing him with his fifteenth-century critics. Without exception (in England at any rate) they remained content with the traditional story. In one case at least Pecock was directly answered. The Abbot John of Wethamstede, in his *Granarium* (a work contemporary with the *Repressor*), tried to rebut the skeptical arguments against the *Donation* altogether, but entirely missed their force.⁴¹ Thus, he meets Pecock's argument from silence not with fresh evidence—something that might well have impressed the bishop—but by analogy with the Gospels. The fall of the idols when Christ entered Egypt, he suggests, is not in Matthew or Mark, yet St. Jerome tells it and not as mere gossip. Nor does lack of notice in the synoptic Gospels discredit the stories about St. John. Silence is thus no argument. As for the tale of Constantine's conversion, authorities abound, and Wethamstede supplies a long list of writers to confirm it—all obviously late, however. For the abbot, comparison of authorities may yield any result, since he recognizes no criterion of authenticity whatsoever. That a lie might be repeated—obvious enough to Pecock—never enters his head, and he seems to have felt that a miraculous story need have no contemporary source whatever to authenticate it. In this context Pecock appears sophisticated and critical indeed. But this was not the only context that the fifteenth century offered.

II

Lorenzo Valla's career and achievement are altogether more familiar than Pecock's. It may be enough then simply to recall some of its chief incidents.⁴² Curiously, even in its external character, Valla's life furnishes a running contrast to the Englishman's. Both attacked more than one traditional opinion; both stirred opposition by their arrogance as well as their ideas; both were accused of heresy. But where the one was ruined, the other was saved by political alliance. And where one was forced to recant what he would surely have defended as orthodoxy, the

⁴¹ See British Museum MS Cotton Nero C.vi. fs. 51–58v, described by E. F. Jacob, 'Florida Verborum Venustas', *Bulletin of the John Rylands Library*, xvii (1933), 274–278. Another reply to Pecock by John Bury is given in extract in Babington's edition of the *Repressor*, II, 567 ff.

⁴² G. Mancini, *Vita di Lorenzo Valla* (Florence, 1891); L. Barozzi and R. Sabbadini, *Studi sul Panormita e sul Valla* (Florence, 1891); Franco Gaeta, *Lorenzino Valla* (Naples, 1955).

other, Valla, was confirmed by papal appointment in opinions which were more overtly heterodox—or at least reformist in intention.

Valla was the younger man by about ten years. His education at once set him apart from men like Pecock. He was taught entirely outside the scholastic curriculum by two of the leading humanists of his generation, Giovanni Aurispa and Leonardo Bruni. This meant an education in the Latin and Greek classical authors and languages, essentially, that is, in grammar and rhetoric—an education impossible to obtain in fifteenth-century England.⁴³ From the first and throughout his career, Valla fought against the Aristotelian logic of the schoolmen; and when he came at last to teach in the universities, he taught the new subject of 'eloquence'.⁴⁴ Like many other Italian humanists he found his vocation as a tutor and Latin secretary; although he had taken orders, this meant an essentially secular career—even perhaps after being appointed to the papal court. But if Valla was neither a philosopher nor a theologian in Pecock's sense, he was interested in the problems of each. His interest, however, was not so much logical as it was philological. He thought that the problems of moral philosophy or Christian metaphysics were more likely of solution by a critical examination of their sources and their language than by dialectic or syllogism. He worked, says Garin, 'to grasp the precise original meaning of words, a meaning that lies beyond any meaning that can be established by traditional logical discussions. In going back to the oldest meaning of a word he aimed at determining its connotations and denotations. And thus he hoped to advance to the sources of the thought that is enshrined in words'.⁴⁵ Valla was

⁴³ On the neglect of grammar in fifteenth-century schools, see for example the testimony of William Bingham, *Cal. Pat. Rolls Henry VI*, III, 295; for its subordination to logic, H. Rashdall, *The Universities of Europe in the Middle Ages*, ed. F. M. Powicke and A. B. Emden (Oxford, 1936), III, 346; J. B. Mullinger, *The University of Cambridge from the Earliest Times to . . . 1535* (Cambridge, 1873), I, 361; Gordon Leff, *Paris and Oxford in the Thirteenth and Fourteenth Centuries* (New York, 1968), pp. 120–122; Brother Bonaventura, 'The Teaching of Latin in Later Medieval England', *Medieval Studies*, xxiii (1961), 1–20.

⁴⁴ Hanna Gray, 'Valla's *Encomium of St. Thomas Aquinas* and the Humanist Conception of Christian Antiquity', *Essays in History and Literature Presented to Stanley Pargellis* (Chicago, 1965), pp. 37–51. Valla's works have been reprinted by Eugenio Garin in the *Monumenta Politica et Philosophica Rariora*, ser. I, nos. 5–6 (Turin, 1962). Especially relevant besides the *Encomium* are the *Dialectical Disputations* and the *Elegantiae*, as also scattered remarks; cf. Francesco Adorno, 'Di Alcune Orazioni e Prefazioni di Lorenzo Valla', *Rinascimento*, v (1954), 191–225.

⁴⁵ Eugenio Garin, *Philosophy and Civic Life in the Renaissance*, trans. Peter Munz (Oxford, 1965), p. 54; cf. Gaeta, chap. iii, 'La nuova filologia e il suo significato', pp. 77–126.

thus, first of all, a grammarian. And his greatest achievement was probably the grammatical work known as *On The Elegancies of the Latin Language*. He wrote, he said, to restore the language of Rome to the Romans, to return it to its glory and purity before the barbarian corruption. That this was desirable no humanist could doubt; the ancients were the models for imitation and close imitation depended upon exact knowledge. Valla aimed to supply it and succeeded as no one before. He showed correct Latin to be determined not by rules—certainly not by reason, as the scholastics had occasionally argued—but by the actual usage of the classical authors. Grammatical study was thus freed from logic; it became in Valla's hands a historical discipline. He was clever enough to see that Latin had been a changing language from its origins—as we have seen there was a hint of that in Pecock—but even more clever to be able to demonstrate differences in style among the classical authors as well as the 'barbarous' medieval writers. He could correct, from the evidence of usage, not only medieval grammarians but even classical authors like Priscian as well.⁴⁶

The *Elegancies* taught all Europe the meaning of classical style. But Valla's work as grammarian was much more various. In characteristic humanist fashion he edited, translated, and commented upon the classical authors, Greek as well as Latin. The historians especially interested him, Herodotus, Thucydides, Livy. Most characteristic and most unusual was his work on the New Testament. The contrast with Pecock could not be more precise. Both were aware of the document as a piece of 'parchment and vellum', as the work of fallible human scribes. But where for Pecock this was unimportant, for Valla it was a fact of great significance. How was one to know the meaning of Scripture if one could not rely on the language before one's eyes? Pecock would no doubt have replied, 'by doom of reason'; indeed he expressly denies the value of grammar to theology at one point in his discussion. 'Grammar and divinity', he wrote, 'be two faculties atwine and asunder departed, and therefore they have their proper to them bounds and marks that

A most useful recent discussion of Valla's philology and its relation to his notion of history is the second chapter of Donald R. Kelley's *Foundations of Modern Historical Scholarship* (New York and London, 1970), pp. 19–50.

⁴⁶ Relevant extracts may be consulted in Garin's ed., *Prosatori Latini del Quattrocento* (Milano, 1952), pp. 594–631; commentary in V. Rossi, *Il Quattrocento* (Milano, 1938), pp. 88 ff. Even outside Italy Valla was admired as *linguae latinae restaurator*; cf. Franco Simone, *The French Renaissance*, trans. H. G. Hall (London, 1969), p. 97.

none of them enter into the other. . . .'⁴⁷ Valla might well have been answering the Englishman when he announced his own intentions. 'Some people deny that theology is subject to the rules of grammar but I say that theologians ought to obey the rules of language, whether written or spoken.' Intelligibility itself, he argued, was at stake. Before anything else could be done, to recover the true meaning of Scripture the text itself had to be established and the corruptions and errors of scribes and translators removed. Valla began the task; he collated three Latin and three Greek codices, showing, where he could, the grammatical misunderstandings and unhappy translations—not excepting from his criticism even Jerome. His emendation of the passage in Romans 1.17, 'The just live by faith', to 'The just shall live by faith', shows how much was at stake. His notes were retrieved by Erasmus and published in 1505; they helped to inspire the next great humanist grammarian to tackle the problem.⁴⁸

Valla was thus, before anything else, a grammatical critic in search of error. His sense of the historicity of language made him exceptionally attuned to anachronisms. Was it any surprise, then, that he discovered them at once in various startling places? Like Pecock he questioned the authorship of the Apostles' Creed;⁴⁹ unlike Pecock he also disputed the apostolic authority of the work of Dionysius the Areopagite. Nor was he satisfied with the authenticity of the letter of Jesus to King Abgarus. To a man of his sensibilities the *Donation of Constantine* was at once and obviously a forgery, and it is his detailed refutation of that document that is his critical masterpiece. But unlike Pecock's work, which was embedded in a complex and difficult philosophical treatise, Valla's tract was an independent work in the new classical idiom. It soon struck a responsive chord and became widely known and influential—particularly, as one might expect, among the Protestants of the next century.

⁴⁷ *Repressor*, I, 32–33.

⁴⁸ E. Harris Harbison, *The Christian Scholar in the Age of the Reformation* (New York, 1956), p. 46; Gianni Zippel, 'Lorenzo Valla e le Origine della Storiografia Umanistica a Venezia', *Rinascimento*, VII (1956), 103, n.; A. Morisi, 'La filologia neotestamentaria di Lorenzo Valla', *Nuova rivista storica*, XLVIII (1964), 35–49. The text has been newly edited by Alessandro Perosa, *Istituto Nazionale di Studi sul Rinascimento, Studi e Testi*, 1 (1970). For Valla's critical work on the ancient historians, see especially R. Westgate, 'The Text of Valla's Translation of Thucydides', *American Philosophical Society Transactions and Proceedings*, LXVII (1936), 240–251, and G. Billanovich, 'Petrarch and the Textual Tradition of Livy', *Journal of the Warburg and Courtauld Institutes*, XIV (1951), 137–208.

⁴⁹ *Book*, pp. 304–305, and in a lost work entitled *The Provoker*, cf. Gascoigne, *op. cit.*, pp. 104, 209.

Yet the *Declamation* was more than an example of grammar. It was a masterpiece of humanist invective as well, a concrete example of the value of eloquence.⁵⁰ Pecock had dismissed rhetoric, in much the way he had disposed of grammar, in a brief passage in the *Repressor*.⁵¹ His own work makes no effort to persuade by anything but its appeal to logic. Valla, on the other hand, would have found Pecock—as he found the scholastic writers generally—barbarous and nonsensical. An appeal to the will and to the emotions was as necessary for him as an appeal to reason. It is eloquence, particularly eloquence informed by the study of history, that rises superior to any philosophy. ‘In my view’, he wrote in the preface to his own history of Ferdinand of Aragon, ‘historians show a greater seriousness in their speeches, greater insight and civic wisdom than the philosophers with their general maxims.’⁵² His *Declamation on the Donation of Constantine* is therefore both a rhetorical and a grammatical work, with the methods of both disciplines applied to a specific historical problem.

The tract begins with a flourish in which truth is proclaimed over death and the papacy; at once the humanist outlines his argument.⁵³ It

⁵⁰ Hanna Gray, ‘Renaissance Humanism: The Pursuit of Eloquence’, *Journal of the History of Ideas*, xxiv (1963), 497–515.

⁵¹ ‘From eldest days continually hitherto, men were wont for to speak and write their words not only in truth but also therewith together for to speak and to write in some gains and beauty and in some delicosity; and into this end and purpose they used certain colors of rhetoric that with them their speeches should be more lusty.’ This was, Pecock argues, however, merely spice and sauce for the meat, and inappropriate for philosophy (*Repressor*, I, 255).

⁵² *De Rebus a Ferdinando Hispaniarum Rege et Majoribus Ejus Gestis*, in *Opera Omnia*, II, 6; cf. Garin, p. 55; Adorno, p. 194. Pecock on the contrary argued specifically against the use of historical examples as a means of furnishing moral wisdom—a commonplace for the humanist rhetoricians. Reason, not examples, was the sole instrument of philosophy (*Reule*, pp. 449–450).

⁵³ Valla’s tract, *De Falso Credita et Ementita Constantini Donatione Declamatio*, ed. W. Schwahn (Leipzig, 1928), appeared first in 1440. It was published by Ulrich von Hutten in 1519 and this edition was employed for an English translation in 1534 under the imprint of Thomas Godfray, *A treatyse of the donation gyven unto Sylvester* (STC 5641). The translation appears to be by William Marshall who also translated the *Defensor Pacis* at about the same time. See James K. McConica, *English Humanists and Reformation Politics* (Oxford, 1965), pp. 136–137. I have used this translation, which is quite literal except for some minor additions, in preference to the more recent English version by Christopher Coleman (New Haven, 1922). I have modernized the spelling as I have all the passages from Pecock so that a comparison between the two authors might be more fairly made. For Hutten’s edition, see Hajo Holborn, *Ulrich von Hutten and the German Reformation* (New Haven, 1937), p. 81. For the use of Godfray’s work by Thomas Cromwell in the English Reformation see the *Letters and Papers of Henry VIII*, 1 April 1534, VII, nos. 422–423.

falls into several fairly distinct parts. The first concerns the inherent plausibility of the *Donation*. This is followed by a discussion of the historical evidence. Then comes a close philological reading, revealing many errors and inconsistencies in the text. And finally there are legal and moral arguments that conclude the work. What Valla says is this: look at the *Donation* and you will see that, even on the face of it, it is highly improbable. If you take the trouble you will find it completely unsubstantiated by evidence. Moreover, it is riddled with clumsy errors that show it to be a forgery. But if all this fails, still you must agree that, even had the *Donation* existed historically, its illegality and immorality make it entirely unacceptable.

As the arguments unfold, it is clear that most of them depend upon a broad reading of classical history. Even the argument over probability, a favorite weapon of the rhetoricians, depends upon putting oneself in Constantine's or Sylvester's place and considering what the likelihood of certain actions and their consequences would have been. Valla invents a series of orations for each of the parties showing what their reactions would have been to such an act. In each case, he argues, the *Donation* would have been rejected by them. More convincingly, he then imagines what would have concretely transpired from the *Donation*, had there been such an event, and asks for evidence of it. For example, if the Church had indeed secured possession of the gift, certain things ought to have followed: an imperial ceremony, the traditional tour of the provinces, etc. What governors and rulers, Valla asks, did the Pope select for the provinces and cities? Were the old magistrates relieved and new ones appointed? What battles were fought and under whose leadership? But there is no evidence, unless 'all these things were done in the night time and therefore no man could see them'. If Sylvester were in possession, then who dispossessed him, for none of his successors held Rome? 'O marvelous and wonderful chance that the empire of Rome which was gotten and won with so great labors with so much bloodshed should so peaceably, so quietly, either be gotten or lost of the Christian priests . . . that no man knoweth or can tell by whom this thing was done. . . .'⁵⁴ Who is there, Valla asks, who does not know ('if he be any thing acquainted with histories') the least details of the Empire, so well has its story been recorded, its consuls, tribunes, censors, etc.? In exasperation he demands of the author of the *Donation*, 'what

⁵⁴ Marshall trans., sig. f ii.

records or what authors can you bring forth of those things?' Obviously none, for the *Donation* is thoroughly implausible even on the face of it.

In place of the missing evidence, Valla supplies his own for the more convincing story of Constantine's continued rule. There is Eutropius, 'which saw Constantine and his sons'; there are the gold coins of Constantine minted after his conversion with inscriptions in Latin (not Greek), of all the Emperors in succession. Where are the coins for the Popes? Moreover, every history deserving the name speaks of Constantine as a Christian from boyhood, long before Sylvester. Both Eusebius and Rufinus, 'well near in Constantine's time', attest to it, as well as Sylvester's own successor, Pope Melchiades.⁵⁵ Valla dismisses the evidence of Gratian and the *Life of Sylvester*, the one as a later interpolation of no credence, the other as spurious altogether. When, later, he returns to consider the *Life*, he reveals, like Pecoek, a general but not complete skepticism of hagiography. Not everything in the lives of the saints is false, 'but I can not suffer that they be mingled with fables and lies'. True Christianity does not need the support of false miracles. Yet even casual examination of the *Life of Sylvester* suggests that it is a bad example of its genre. For example, it tells the story of an enormous serpent consuming Rome with its poisonous breath, and only pacified by devouring young maidens, until bound in its cave by Sylvester. Is this credible? Valla summons all his knowledge of dragons, classical and biblical, to deny its plausibility. But that story is only one of the incredible tales of the *Life*; such a document surely can carry no conviction.

Valla is now ready to analyze the text and he begins a massive philological assault upon the document. Page upon page of criticism exposes the *Donation* as riddled with linguistic errors and anachronisms. A few examples will show his method. The very title of the gift, 'the page of the privilege' (*paginam privilegii*), is peculiar. 'Callest thou the donation of the world a privilege?'⁵⁶ Could it possibly be written so in such a document? But if the title is ridiculous, what are we to imagine of the rest? At once we hear of imperial 'satraps'. Whoever heard them mentioned in the councils of the Romans? Valla can remember neither Roman nor provincial 'satraps' in any of his reading. Yet here they may be found more important even than the Senate. Then there are the 'nobles' (*optimates*) spoken of in a way hardly consonant with the customs of the

⁵⁵ Here Valla succumbs to a forgery every bit as obvious as the *Donation*; cf. Coleman 73, n.

⁵⁶ Sig. G ii.

Empire, and there is the phrase 'the people subject to the Roman Church' (*Romanae ecclesiae subiacens*), rather than 'the Roman people'. Passage by passage, Valla exposes the faulty language of the document.

His concern for style reveals the bad and inappropriate Latin of the work. Thus, we are told that Constantine chose the apostles, 'to be [*esse*] his intercessors', instead of 'as his intercessors'. Valla wonders, 'Did the scribes of the emperors (because I will not say the horsekeepers) speak after this manner and fashion in thy time?' The scribe must have put in the infinitive (*esse*) to make the words fit more trimly together! There is the phrase 'Our imperial power' (*nostra terrena imperialis potestas*), 'where he joineth two adjectives without a conjunction copulative'. And 'clemency of our imperial serenity' instead of 'grandeur and majesty'; 'chief over the priest' instead of 'chief of the priests', etc.⁵⁷

There are still other kinds of faulty usage that Valla's superior knowledge of Roman affairs helps to reveal. Thus, the diadem is made of gold but ought to have been of cloth. The *Donation* speaks of a tiara (*phrygium*). 'How great barbarousness is there in these words: who ever heard this word Phrigium used in the Latin tongue?' Thus, not only is the document shown to be spurious but it is revealed to be a later forgery. For, Valla asks, 'doth not the very barbarousness of the manner of speaking witness openly: that this carol hath been feigned not in the time of Constantine but in a time more late?'⁵⁸ There is still more to Valla's argument, but he is ready at last to add his conclusive point: even if true, the *Donation* would be illegal and immoral and hence invalid anyway.

The *Declamation*, it should be said, was written by Valla to support the King of Naples in a territorial dispute with the Pope. He was very proud of its rhetoric. But although it is a polemical and rhetorical production, it is obviously a first-rate piece of historical criticism as well. Valla has not the mastery of the sources of a modern historian but his range is very much wider than Pecoock's. To a broader knowledge of the literary authorities, Greek as well as Latin, he adds, besides, information derived from coins and inscriptions. His familiarity with the customs, legal forms, and the language of the fourth century is extensive enough to declare the *Donation* at once anachronistic. For the humanist, no as-

⁵⁷ Sigs. G iv *et seq.* There are other examples of anachronism here as where Valla exposes the premature reference to Constantinople as a patriarchate. He also criticizes the faulty geography of the forger.

⁵⁸ Sig. J ii.

pect of antiquity was uninteresting; all sources of information had become possible. The modern idea of research was born of the classical philologist's concern to illuminate his texts, to understand them again as they had been written. Thus Valla turns upon the *Donation* the full equipment of his craft. The existence of a historical problem impels him to examine the full range of relevant sources, not simply to compare those conveniently at hand. His scorn for the anonymous forger is partly due to his rhetorical posture; it is also the genuine response of a humanist to the apparent ignorance and clumsy Latin of the author. The arguments from silence and from the contradictions of later events are more convincing than Pecock's because Valla's knowledge is greater and more authoritative. His comparison of the sources is also sounder although he too takes some of the argument for granted and makes some important errors. But it is Valla's 'grammatical' argument that is in the end the most significant and persuasive and provides the *coup de grâce* to the *Donation*. He has gone back to the texts and subjected them to a systematic philological criticism. By considering the language of his sources and by setting them into their contemporary context, he has recaptured their meaning and intention—at least sufficiently to declare the *Donation* conclusively anachronistic. Renaissance grammar, it turns out, is more efficacious for the solution of a historical problem than scholastic logic, and the humanist much the superior historian to his rival the professional theologian.⁵⁹

Yet once again there was more to be done and Valla does not do it. The modern historian is not satisfied merely with the destructive argument. The *Donation* is not what it purports to be; what is it then? When was it written and why?⁶⁰ It is easy to see why Valla stops short. He is not writing history; he is writing polemic. He has satisfied the needs of his patron and of the rhetorical declamation.⁶¹ To tell the story of Con-

⁵⁹ See, as another example, Valla's ridicule of the justification for papal headship, advanced by Pecock and many others, that Cephas was the name given to Peter (Babington, *Repressor*, I, xxiv). For the origin of this error, see Walter Ullman, *The Individual and Society in the Middle Ages* (Baltimore, 1966), p. 9, n.

⁶⁰ For an example of the modern effort at a constructive argument, see Paul Scheffer-Boichorst, *Neue Forschungen über die Konstantinische Schenkung in Mittheilungen des Instituts für österr. Geschichtsforschung*, x (1889), 302 ff.; xi (1890), 128 ff. Through close examination of the style, vocabulary, and ideas, he places the forgery in the papal chancery of either Stephen II or Paul I, A.D. 752–767, a conclusion generally held today. For other views, however, see Maffei, pp. 7–9; Ullmann, *Growth*, p. 74, n.

⁶¹ Döllinger, as a result, described Valla's work as 'an artistic production, an eloquent declamation, [rather] than a calm historical investigation'. For this reason he even preferred Pecock, *op. cit.*, p. 175.

stantine's reign, or of the accretion of papal temporalities, in a thorough and critical fashion, remained a work for the future. In fact, it was a task beyond the powers or at least the interests of Valla and his contemporaries. The demands of eloquence set limits to the employment of scholarly technique; rhetoric remained for a long time in conflict with grammar, in the writing of history. It was a very long time before historians would use the techniques of humanist philology systematically to reconstruct the past. Furthermore the humanists for the most part had no interest in and only little sympathy for the Middle Ages. Their very sensitivity to the changes in culture, from ancient to medieval to renaissance, awoke a historical sensibility but then limited it. For the classical revival involved not only an apprehension of change but a judgment upon it—a judgment which had the effect of limiting interest and understanding for the whole long period after antiquity.⁶²

But we should not be too eager to judge the past by the standards of the present. If Pecock and Valla in different ways and in different degrees fail to meet the historiographical standards of the present, we should no more condemn them than more superficial critics have praised them for their modernity. At the same time, we must not confuse their different techniques or their different attitudes toward history that were at bottom very unlike. Of the two, it is clear that we stand closer to Valla; and it is to renaissance philology, rather than to medieval logic, that the future of historical method belonged. But how it came to pass that Valla's technique was transformed from philology and polemic into a systematic and constructive historiographical method is another and still not very well known story. In any case, and of this we may be sure, it did not occur until long after the exposure of the *Donation of Constantine*.

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⁶² Kelley remarks, for example, that while Valla could discriminate with skill among several classical styles and periods (and thus reveal an authentic historical relativism), with the Middle Ages his 'sense of discrimination diminished as his disgust grew'. With the fall of Rome, for Valla, there was only decline and disintegration. Valla was thus disinclined to attempt either to date or to discuss the *Donation* in any way except simply to show its non-classical character; cf. Kelley, *Foundations*, p. 37.